

IBM Style: quick reference

Follow *IBM Style* to ensure that Red Hat documentation is consistent across the portfolio of Red Hat products. Use this quick reference guide to understand the most common errors that are present in our writing.

For the full extent of IBM style rules, use your Red Hat email address to log in to *IBM Style* online: <https://www.ibm.com/docs/en/ibm-style>

Language and grammar	
Anthropomorphism	Avoid using anthropomorphism, which attributes human characteristics to inanimate objects.
Capitalization	Use sentence-style capitalization for headings.
Future tense	Avoid using future tense. Use present tense when possible.
Passive voice	Avoid using passive voice. Use active voice as much as possible.
Phrasal verbs	Replace phrasal verbs with one-word alternatives when possible.
Punctuation	
Colons and semicolons	Use colons and semi-colons correctly.
Commas in restrictive and nonrestrictive clauses	Use commas to separate nonrestrictive (nonessential) clauses.
Possessives and apostrophes	Do not use apostrophes to indicate possessives of brand names, abbreviations, or product names.
Formatting and organization	
Incomplete sentences	Avoid incomplete sentences.
Optional and conditional steps	Use correct formatting for optional and conditional steps.
Parallelism	Use parallelism in lists.
Single-step procedures	Use a bullet point for single-step procedures or prerequisites.
Titles and headings	Write descriptive and findable titles and headings.
Unordered lists	Use an unordered list when the sequence is not significant.
Structure	
Inline links	Limit the use of inline links.
Computer interfaces	
Command line	Refer to the command line consistently.
UI elements	Refer to user interface (UI) elements consistently.
Screen captures (screenshots)	Avoid screen captures unless text alone is insufficient.
Word usage	
Avoid these words	Omit or avoid the following commonly-found words or constructions.

The information in this quick reference is based on the following resources:

- *IBM Style*. Latest update: January 2021.
- *Developing Quality Technical Information: A Handbook for Writers and Editors* first printed June 2014, updated 2014.
- The [Red Hat supplementary style guide for product documentation](#).

To suggest a topic or to provide feedback, email ibm-style-quickref@redhat.com

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